



Orthodox Mission among the Roma

in Central Slovakia

CHRISTIAN ROMA MISSION

Martin Halík

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ThDr. Martin Halík

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Contents

Foreword

Introduction

Theory and History

1.1. The History of the Roma Ethnic Group in Europe

1.2. The Roma and Orthodoxy

The Greek Origin of the Word “Gypsy” (cigán)

1.3. The Mission of Cyril and Methodius in the Territory of Slovakia and Its Legacy for the Present-Day Roma Mission

A Simple People and the Need to Use the Native Language

Literature in the Romani Language

The Missing Humble Servant

1.4. The Principles of the Missionary Work of the Holy Apostle Paul and Their Application in the Roma Mission

The Dispersion of the Jews throughout the Empire as a Means of Spreading the Gospel

The Apostle Paul Went to Those to Whom Others Did Not Go

Personal Example and Involvement in the Mission

To the Greeks as a Greek and to the Jews as a Jew

Constant Pastoral Care and Teaching of Spiritual Children through Co-workers, Letters and Repeated Visits

1.5. The Mission in Klenovec

The Mission in Klenovec in Numbers – February 2022

Orthodoxy Suits the Roma

What the Situation Was Like in Klenovec and the Surrounding Area

Now Is the Time to Act, and We Can Save Many

Practice

2.1. How to Prepare for Mission

Fear of the Settlement in Klenovec and the First Prayers

2.2. How to Take the First Step

The First Step into the Settlement of Mútnik

The Example of the Heterodox – from a Gift to the Bible

The Second Step – Regular Visits

The Roma Have Time and Open Doors

God's Grace during a Visit

2.3. The Colour of the Roma Settlements: Not All Roma Are Alike

Pious Zuzka

Hard-Working Vojto and His Wife Janka

Humility and Gratitude for Bare Life

2.4. When Need Is Greatest, God's Help Is Nearest

2.5. Children as the Foundation of the Building

2.6. Kerygma and the Gospel

2.7. The Roma and Music

No One Listened to Me, So I Sang to Them

Christian Roma Songs of the Heterodox

2.8. The First Teaching of Children

2.9. Thefts

Our Experience

2.10. Living in the Settlement

2.11. The Family in the Roma Mission

2.12. Roman Catholic or Orthodox

2.13. Chrismation or a Second Baptism

Beware of the Differences

The Grace of God in Baptism among the Roma

2.14. The Liturgical Language

2.15. Trips

2.16. Missionary Activity in Other Settlements

Foreword

Dear readers,

the publication of this book fills me with great joy, because it was written as the fruit of the personal spiritual, philanthropic and missionary experience of its author, whom I have known personally for several years. I deeply respect the ministry that Martin Halík and his wife Michaela carry out among the Roma of Central Slovakia, because it is built on unquestionable selflessness, sincere love and respect for the Roma. I consider the greatest value of this book to be the fact that reading it can inspire the reader to work and serve among the poorest citizens of our country. It is not merely dry theory acquired through years of study, but also the result of practical ministry, empirical knowledge, patient self-sacrifice, forbearance, humility and mercy. That is also why every line of the book is filled with the grace of God, which, as one reads, transforms the heart and fills it with the strength and warmth of understanding and sincere friendship.

Archpriest Doc. ThDr. Štefan Pružinský, PhD., archdean

Introduction

“Do not cling to the beauty of a human face, but look at the soul of the person. Do not look at what a person is wearing (the body is a temporary garment), but at the one who wears the garment. Do not look at the splendour of the house, but at the one who lives in the house and what he is like; otherwise you offend the image of God in man.”

— Jan Kronštadský: *Můj život v Kristu* (výbor). Kostelní Vydří 2014, p. 22.

Mission is part of the life of the Church and has given us many saints; many people still know their lives, and they are an example to us in faith in God, love for people and hope in the resurrection. The greatest of them was perhaps the Apostle Paul, who, to encourage Timothy and the other missionaries, wrote:

“The hardworking farmer must be first to partake of the crops.”¹

That is why we have hope of an eternal reward even when the work is hard and the harvest is poor. For this hope, together with love, was the motivation and the fuel for all missionaries. Without this hope of life after death, missionaries would be most wretched and pitiable, as St Paul said:

“If in this life only we have hope in Christ, we are of all men the most pitiable.”²

Missionaries were often killed, sad and weary. All these feelings are captured in the words of Jesus:

“O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, the one who kills the prophets and stones those who are sent to her! How often I wanted to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, but you were not willing!”

The fruit of their labour is sometimes hidden, sometimes it becomes visible only after their death, as was the case, for example, with the Czech prince Wenceslas, and at other times it is visible earlier, as in the life of St Nicholas of Japan.

In Slovakia the presence of the Roma nation is becoming ever more pronounced; they are content here and often return here from England, Germany and other countries where they went to work for several years. Young Slovaks, on the contrary, often leave Slovakia or move from villages to towns. Because of these and other factors, Orthodox parishes in the countryside are slowly dying out. A rare bright example is the village of Markovce in Zemplín, where they succeeded in involving the Roma in parish life and saved the parish from impending extinction. That is why Markovce is today already predominantly Roma. Where parishioners resist this, they do manage to preserve their comfort and a quiet ecclesial old age, but the Church was not meant to live out its days on earth, but to leaven the earth, just as Jesus said:

“To what shall I liken the kingdom of God? It is like leaven, which a woman took and hid in three measures of meal till it was all leavened.”³

How can one manage this, and where can one find the strength for it? Here human strength is pitiful, but God’s help is very near. During the seven years of the Roma mission the Lord always helped me very intensely through the Eucharist – much as He helped St John of Kronstadt, who drew strength from the Lord through daily communion. Before the Liturgy I was often determined to leave everything and run away, but God touched me, helped me to forgive everything, to always begin anew, and filled me with love for these people, whom I had not been fond of before. It was not easy; several times the Roma damaged the clubhouse, they stole my firewood, my guitar, food and much else. Later they burgled my house, once I was hit on the head with a stone, another time they threatened me with an axe. Instead of gratitude I later often heard abuse. But it is not only about the bad and the unpleasant; I also experience a great deal of good. Never have so many people kissed me, whether sober or drunk, never have so many people welcomed me, embraced me and helped me as during the Roma mission. In my life both the sweet and the bitter words of Christ have been fulfilled:

“Amen, I say to you: there is no one who has left house or brothers or sisters or mother or father or children or lands, for My sake and the Gospel’s, who shall not receive a hundredfold now in this time – houses and brothers and sisters and mothers and children and lands, with persecutions – and in the age to come, eternal life.”

Notes

1 2 Tim 4:7

2 1 Cor 15:19

3 Luke 13:20–21

Theory and History

“And the Lord said: Indeed the people are one and they all have one language, and this is what they begin to do; now nothing that they propose to do will be withheld from them. Come, let Us go down and there confuse their language, that they may not understand one another’s speech. So the Lord scattered them abroad from there over the face of all the earth, and they ceased building the city.”

— Gen 11:6–8

1.1. The History of the Roma Ethnic Group in Europe

The Lord commanded Noah and his descendants to fill the earth,⁴ but they gathered together and rejected God's will. The consequence of this is the different languages of all nations. Animals understand one another even though they come from different continents, but people no longer do. The Roma are proof of how a different language can make a person a foreigner in the land where he was born. They are a nation which, from the moment it left the Byzantine Empire (because of war, oppression by the Muslims and a ruined economy), has lived for centuries scattered in various countries, and its members still come across as foreigners (they have not assimilated). In their livelihood the Roma depend on a functioning economy, because they were never farmers, but always nomads – who, however, did not have great herds like Abraham, but offered various services in exchange for food and money, much like today's tertiary sector. There are various conjectures about the origin of the Roma. Above all because of the considerable similarity between the Romani language and Hindi, there has been no doubt for two centuries now that the Roma originally come from India. The theories speculate rather about which part of India and which caste they come from. Some label this theory as romanticism, but their efforts seem tendentious to me, as if intended only to prove the power of prejudice and stereotype.⁵ The first comparison was made around 1760 by the Hungarian student Stefan Vályim after meeting Indians at the theological school in Leiden. In language and appearance they reminded him of the Roma from around Komárno.⁶ Further studies, which have been preserved and are cited, were made by A. F. Pott (1844–1845) and Fr. Miklosich (1872–1877), who on the basis of language confirmed that the Roma come from India and that they spent a long time in Greece (Byzantium) and in Slavic countries.⁷

If we know Roma culture at least a little, we too can make this comparison with the help of today's technology. We need to look for words that have been used continuously in the Roma community despite changes in lifestyle, from the time of their journey out of India right up to the present day. For example, words like “hot water”, because people have always heated water for washing and cooking. Hot water in Romani is “tato páni”, and in Hindi it is likewise “tato páni”. This is an observation of a friend of mine who spent a year on mission in India. For the other words in Table 1 I used a translation tool.

SLOVAK	HINDI	ROMANI	NOTES
horse	घोड़ा [ghora]	gra	
night	रात [rát]	ráti	
old (fem.)	पुराना [puraana]	phura	The “H” is voiceless, so in Romani it can also be written as pura. An “N” is added at the end of a word and indicates the infinitive. That gives us puran. An “A” at the end of a word marks the feminine gender. The Romani language shortens words much like French does, the stress falls on the second syllable, and so we arrive at puraana.
hungry	भूखा [bhookha]	bokhal	The “h” is voiceless and often changes to “ch” or drops out – which is why in Hindi it can also be written as bokha
one (fem.)	एक [ek]	jekh	The “j” helps to pronounce the vowel at the beginning of the word; the “h” is again voiceless and is typically added in Romani.
yes	हाँ [haan]	ha	
to eat	खाने [khaane]	haan	in eastern Slovakia one says “chaan”
fire	आग [aag]	jaag(h)	

Table 1: A comparison of Hindi and Romani in the Central Slovak dialect

I was personally very surprised when I discovered that a caste system operates among the Roma. It is evident even today, when the Roma sort themselves among one another by skin colour, and “being black” is an insult. Some even avoid going outside much so as not to get a tan and turn darker. Others avoid working in the sun because they know they will then get darker. The Roma from the settlement are usually the lowest caste, which is referred to in the village as filth, and the Roma living in the village also isolate themselves from them. D. Doubek has similar findings from fieldwork in Bohemia,⁸ which means that this is a widespread trait.

The Roma appeared in Europe at the beginning of the 15th century. From their language one can see that they bypassed Arabia but stayed for a time in Armenia and Byzantium (they have many Armenian and Greek words across the European Romani dialects). We know of only two mentions of the Roma from the period before the 12th century. The first is connected with an emperor who was labelled a Rom⁹ because he knew how to work well with horses. The second is from the 11th century, from the text “The Life of St George the Athonite”, where the Roma are invited to an area of wild beasts in order to poison and kill them with their sorcery. After their great success the

emperor Constantine IX (who reigned from 1042 to 1055) invited them to the royal court to demonstrate this poisoning to him. St George was also present at the court at that time, but he did not like the whole performance, just as he did not like the killing of the animals. So he blessed the poisoned meat with the sign of the cross in front of everyone, and to everyone's surprise the dog was not poisoned. The emperor was delighted by this and exclaimed that as long as St George was at the court, he knew he need fear neither poison nor sorcerers.¹⁰ The beginning of the permanent occupation of the Byzantine Empire (1396–1453) would correspond to the arrival of the Roma in Europe, which is dated precisely to this period. Several streams can be seen there: a small part remained on the territory of Turkey and Greece, and these are often still regarded as Turks today. Another part moved only a short distance, to Serbia and Romania, where there are now the most Roma. Another group travelled further north (Ukraine, Poland, Russia, Lithuania, Latvia, Estonia, Finland), another to the west (Italy, Spain), and yet another part gradually through Romania, Hungary, Slovakia and Bohemia to Germany, France and England. Many Roma reached as far as Spain itself, where they very strongly influenced its music and culture.¹¹ Most of this knowledge is based above all on historical mentions and on the comparison of dialects. Anyone who learns Romani will, with a little practice, understand several dialects well. I have observed that with a little effort the Roma can make themselves understood across the whole of Europe. This happens especially in a difficult life situation, or when young people fall in love with each other. To me personally the Slovak, Serbian and Russian dialects seem very close.¹² Although their histories have been different for five centuries now, the language is still similar. It is true, however, that new and less frequently used words differ, which is due to the fact that Romani does not have very many written works, and so the language has not preserved a large vocabulary. This is changing, however, thanks to the telephone and Facebook. For the Roma have now begun to write. For the time being everyone writes as he hears, but with every day the conditions for the emergence of a standard written form of Romani are growing. Songs on YouTube, too, nowadays carry this language from one corner of Europe to another.

An interesting feature of the Roma nation is the fact that they live scattered throughout the Anglo-European world in diasporas, much as the Jewish nation once did. Together with the Jewish nation they later also shared a death sentence, namely in the time of Adolf Hitler. I believe that when they turn fully to God, their potential is enormous. In the Roma mission I experience feeling at home in many Roma communities where there are relatives, or where Roma from the settlements in which

we work have married into. I know that there I will find accommodation and support for the mission, but unfortunately I do not have enough time to make use of it. It reminds me of the journeys of the Apostle Paul, when he went to preach to the Jews scattered throughout Europe (Salamis, Antioch in Pisidia, Iconium, Lystra¹³ and many others), among whom he often found initial support and the first believers, and they provided him with a base so that he could then go on to preach in the city to the Gentiles as well.

Notes

⁴ Gen 9:1

⁵ See BITTNEROVÁ, D. et al.: *Etnické komunity - Romové*. Praha 2013, p. 30

⁶ See HORTIS, S. A.: *Cigáni v Uhorsku : o dnešnom stave, zvláštnych mravoch a spôsobe života, ako aj o ostatných vlastnostiach a danostiach Cigánov v Uhorsku*. Bratislava 1995, p. 203.

⁷ SOULIS, G. C.: *The Gypsies in the Byzantine Empire and the Balkans in the Late Middle Ages*. In: *Dumbarton Oaks Papers*, Trustees for Harvard University 1961, vol. 15, p. 143. Available online: <https://doi.org/10.2307/1291178>

⁸ See BITTNEROVÁ, D. et al.: *Etnické komunity - Romové*. Praha 2013, p. 20

⁹ From a lecture by Prof. ThDr. Ján Šafin PhD. at the PBF in the course *History of Religions* (2019)

¹⁰ SOULIS, G. C.: *The Gypsies in the Byzantine Empire and the Balkans in the Late Middle Ages*, p. 145

¹¹ Small groups of Roma also arrived earlier; according to <https://archiv.vlada.gov.sk/romovia/3632/dejiny-romov.html> we have reports of their presence in Slovakia as early as the 14th century. According to general sources, however, their “great” arrival is recorded throughout Europe in the first half of the 15th century. The whole situation can be explained by the decline of the economy of the Byzantine Empire after the occupation of its territory by the Ottoman Turks, which preceded the conquest of Constantinople. The victories of the Turks in 1389 at Kosovo Polje and in 1396 at Nicopolis are well known; they testify to the inability of the Byzantine metropolis to prevent foreign armies from crossing its territory, and to the consequent need of the Roma to flee from the Ottoman Turks, whose conduct towards villagers is known from the history of Slovakia as well.

¹² Serbian, Slovak and Russian are the only dialects I have had the opportunity to compare in books and videos. The New Testament has been translated into East Slovak Romani and is available at biblia.sk, in print and on YouTube <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0vtyyO4FobE>; into Central Slovak Romani the book *Mri eľšebni Biblija* has been translated, the translation being by PhDr. Ján Berky-Luborecký. In Serbian Romani (the Arli-Balkan dialect) there are songs by Sasa Bakic <https://youtube.com/playlist?list=PLGdXozkVaYWzgwDixO6-h64LOUJ8NlZXi> and the Orthodox *Služebnik* by Трифун Димић. In Russian Romani I had at my disposal the Gospel *Святое Евангелие от Марка* на русском и цыганском языках (диалект русских цыган), translated by Георгий Цветков.

¹³ Acts 13:5, 13–14; 14:1; 16:1

1.2. The Roma and Orthodoxy

At first glance it may seem to some that the Roma have nothing in common with Orthodoxy. But since we already know Roma history, we know that the Roma spent the last millennium among Orthodox believers. These encounters were not always positive, and it is true that the Roma acceptance of Christianity combined with sorcery received directives from church authorities as early as the 12th century. For example, Patriarch Athanasius I of Constantinople (1289–1293 and 1303–1309) wrote to all the clergy that they should warn the faithful against visiting soothsayers, bear-charmers and snake-charmers, and above all that they should not let Gypsies (ἄτσιγγανος - atsinganos/acinganos) into their homes, because they teach diabolical things.¹⁴ This combination of sorcery or paganism with Christianity is a common phenomenon in the early period after the acceptance of Christianity. It takes many years for a community to change customs lived for centuries. Even the Israelites did not succeed in rooting out the paganism of the original nations, which is why they were punished with the Babylonian captivity. We see a similar mixture of paganism and Christianity in Bohemia too, in the life of Prince Wenceslas,¹⁵ and in the Paraguayan mission among the Indians.¹⁶ The coexistence of the Roma and the Byzantines worked. Byzantium was a very multicultural land, like every prosperous great power, and according to linguists the Roma even took up the smith's craft precisely in Byzantium.¹⁷ The Roma accepted Christian teaching and left the Byzantine Empire only when Muslim armies began to oppress its territory and inhabitants.

There is not much information about how the Roma reached Byzantium; however, there are many Armenian words in Romani, so it is presumed that they came from Armenia in the course of Armenia's subjugation to the Byzantine Empire.¹⁸ The struggles between Armenia and Byzantium, however, lasted from the 6th century to the 10th century. For this reason, wherever they are now, half of their history in Europe was spent in Orthodox Byzantium. The Roma in Serbia, Ukraine, Romania, Greece and Russia in fact do not even know any other churches.

They are also given away by their great fondness for icons, golden churches, bright colours and singing, and likewise by their reverence for priests and their kissing of the cross. All these customs suggest that these things are ingrained in them, just as in other Orthodox nations. And not only that: prayer by a candle (unfortunately also cursing) comes naturally to them, as does the use of holy water when something haunts their

home, or drinking holy water for health. Burial on the third day is still part of Roma culture today, even though in the Western churches this is no longer the custom.

The Roma are peaceable people; they do not rebel and they accept the religion of the majority, but their way of life changes more slowly. They often attach various tales and sorcery to their religion, so that from historical sources we can cite various preventive measures of the Church, such as excommunication by the Archbishop of Paris or by the Patriarch of Constantinople. They remind one of the Cretans, when the Apostle Paul wrote about them to Titus:

“For there are many insubordinate, both idle talkers and deceivers... whose mouths must be stopped, who subvert whole households, teaching things which they ought not, for the sake of dishonest gain. One of them, a prophet of their own, said: Cretans are always liars, evil beasts, lazy gluttons. This testimony is true. Therefore rebuke them sharply, that they may be sound in the faith, not giving heed to Jewish fables and commandments of men who turn from the truth.”¹⁹

“I am the good shepherd; and I know My sheep, and am known by My own. As the Father knows Me, even so I know the Father; and I lay down My life for the sheep. And other sheep I have which are not of this fold; them also I must bring, and they will hear My voice; and there will be one flock and one shepherd.”

— John 10:14–16

The Greek Origin of the Word “Gypsy” (cigán)

The Slovak word “cigán” (Gypsy) is derived from the Greek word *atsinganos* (ἄτσιγγανος), various forms of which are still used today to designate the Roma across Europe (see Table 2). It is enough to replace the letters “ts” with our closest letter, “c”, and the resemblance is considerable: “a-ci-n-gan-os”. Related to it is the Greek word “ἄτσιγγανοί”, which in church writings designates a heretic and a sorcerer – which corresponds to several historical sources about problems with the Roma in Byzantium. In the translation of the Trebník into Russian, the word ἄτσιγγανος was replaced by the word *Cigán* (Цыган). In his work “Chronographia”, Theophanes explains the word “ἄθίγγανοι” as a term designating heretics living mainly in Phrygia and Lycaonia. From other sources we know that the Roma, just like these heretics, engaged in fortune-telling and sorcery, which is why they were associated with them and received

the same designation.²⁰ To this day the Roma in Greece are called by a very similar name, “τσιγγάνος”.

LANGUAGE	TERM
Greek	τσιγγάνος
French	tsigane
Czech	cikán
Slovenian	cigan
Bulgarian	Циганин
Polish	cygan
Romanian	țigan
Russian	Цыган
Serbian	циган
German	Zigeuner
Italian	zingaro
Swedish	zigenare
Norwegian	sigøyner
Turkish	çingene

Notes

¹⁴ ATHANASIUS I OF CONSTANTINOPLE, Vat. gr. 2219, p. 120; a similar text also on pp. 225–226

¹⁵ See LUDVÍKOVSKÝ, J.: Kristiánova legenda: život a umučení svatého Václava a jeho báby svaté Ludmily.

¹⁶ See CHARLEVOIX, P. F. X.: Paraguay v době jezuitských redukcí.

¹⁷ Mentioned by the director of the Museum of Romani Culture in Brno in the podcast “Včera, dnes a zítra” <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PfAyO9V6gXw>

¹⁸ See SOULIS, G. C.: The Gypsies in the Byzantine Empire and the Balkans in the Late Middle Ages, p. 144

¹⁹ Titus 1:10–14

²⁰ See Dejiny Rómov. archiv.vlada.gov.sk (online). [accessed 2021-30-12]. Available online <https://archiv.vlada.gov.sk/romovia/3632/dejiny-romov.html>

1.3. The Mission of Cyril and Methodius in the Territory of Slovakia and Its Legacy for the Present-Day Roma Mission

The mission of Cyril and Methodius was an exceptional event in the history of the Slavs. In the 9th century the Byzantine nation sent out far more missions than before.²¹ Mostly they sent bishops, teachers and priests at the request of local Christians or rulers. The first missionaries were often slaves, captives or refugees from Christian lands, as was also the case with St Nina and Georgia. It was similar in the case of Cyril and Methodius, who were sent at the request of the Slavic prince Rastislav.

Cyril was a man who decided that “he would not waste his days in the bustle of this life.”²² He was a learned man, but above all a man of prayer and of God’s grace, willing to die for Christ, gathering not riches but virtues. He obeyed the emperor’s call to a mission among the Muslims and the Jews, who tried to poison him. In the case of the Slavs, however, he came up against a greater obstacle, which he mentions as follows: “I shall go there with joy if they have letters for their language.”²³ The Slavs were a simple people and did not understand theology, as Prince Rastislav writes:

“we Slavs (are) a simple people,” and further, “many teachers have come to us, Christians from Italy, from Greece and from Germany, teaching us in various ways...,”²⁴ but “we do not have such a teacher who would explain to us the true faith in our own language.”²⁵

Their mission was successful; the people accepted the script revealed by God, and several priests were ordained. But their legacy was forgotten. Even now there is a nation of believers here among us who lack teachers, the Holy Scriptures, the Liturgy and literature. Even today the Roma are forced to communicate, to learn and to receive catechesis in foreign languages, and the result is similar to that before the arrival of Saints Cyril and Methodius – a poorly instructed nation without its own teachers and Liturgy. Cyril and Methodius came to our ancestors, the “barbarians”; they ate with them, lived among them, got lice and fleas, and taught their children and young men to be priests. For this openness and for their mission they tasted criticism and persecution. Just like those who today help the despised Roma nation and proclaim Christ to it.

One can notice several similarities between the Roma and the Slavs of that time:

1. They were a simple people, which is why Rastislav asks for a teacher in their own language, because we understand most easily something that is in our native language, especially when it is something new.
2. The need for literature in the native language. This was St Cyril's condition for the ministry to have the desired effect.
3. The lack of a humble servant who does not despise the uneducated, but stoops down and imitates Christ, who humbled Himself and became man in order to raise man up.

A Simple People and the Need to Use the Native Language

The Roma from the settlements go on to secondary school only very exceptionally, and their speech is much less abstract. Many comparisons do not succeed if they are not taken from their own life, and sometimes others have to explain their meaning to them. At such times the Roma mostly switch to Romani and the problem is solved. Many holy preachers of the Church focused on preaching in the speech of the people and not in the vocabulary of theologians, and also on the related use of the mother tongue. In a foreign language one always understands with more difficulty; one has to concentrate more and it takes a moment. When I want immediate attention, I always use Romani sentences, e.g. “quiet, listen to me – čiten, šun ma”, “wait – užaren”, “watch out, a car – motori avel”, “come here – avorde”. When I came to a new settlement, everyone fell silent only when the social worker spoke to them in Romani. The Pentecostals (Pentecostal Protestants) also often preach in the settlements in Romani. There is no problem in mixing languages when speaking if you do not know the expressions or are only learning Romani. Mixing Romani and Slovak is normal for them.

“His life, even if told only briefly, shows what he was like, so that whoever hears it and wishes to become like him may take up alacrity and reject sloth, as the apostle said: Imitate me, just as I also imitate Christ.”

— The Life of Constantine and the Life of Methodius, ĎURICA, S. M.: Život Konštantína a život Metoda, Panónske legendy. Turany 2013, p. 19

Literature in the Romani Language

The Roma already know how to write; at school each of them learns the letters of his country, and slight modifications easily turn that script into a Romani one. With literature it is much worse. The Roma cannot read Romani, because they learn to read

in Slovak. The Romani language joins words together like French and, unlike Slovak, places the stress on the second syllable. Some sounds are written in a tongue-twisting way, and “dž”, “kh”, “ph” cause problems for an inexperienced reader (especially for Roma who see something like this written for the first time). Part of our mission is teaching children, and as the children’s literacy gradually improves, we make ever more use of their mother tongue in written form as well. It is successful, but they have to be taught gradually, and not given a Romani translation of the Bible straight away (we tried that, but it was not successful). Just as in the Church we learn to read Church Slavonic, so too the Roma need time to learn to read in Romani, even though they already know the script and it is their native language. Saints Cyril and Methodius, too, taught their pupils, who were assigned to them by Rastislav and Kocel.

The Missing Humble Servant

“Christ as God voluntarily humbled Himself, and as man He was humble, in order to lead human nature to theosis...”²⁶

If we want to help someone, we have to stoop down to him, come to him and not despise him. In the Holy Scriptures Christ warns us against the leaven of the Pharisees, and the Holy Scriptures were written for our sake, for us believers. The faults of the Pharisees are often mentioned in the Gospel, and their chief mark is contempt for less pious people. Christ calls us to eat what is set before us, to accept the first lodging offered and not to move to a better place in the course of the mission. St Cyril is an example to us in this. He left the imperial court in what was then the most beautiful city and went on mission among the Arabs, the Khazars and the Slavs. He never complained, never slackened, and obediently went wherever he was sent. The first Pentecostal missionaries in Spiš, who came there from Ostrava and founded the congregation “Maranatha”, lived in the settlements and did not complain.²⁷ The fruit of this ministry was enormous; there were even television reports about it. Hundreds of Roma changed their lives and around a thousand attended the Sunday sermons. Over time one of them, who was the chief of these preachers, bought himself a big house and a nice car. Later sin came: the preacher in question embezzled the congregation’s money, and the mission suffered a great blow as a result. The assembly split into two congregations and the preacher stepped down from the ministry. Humility was the water that helped the seed of the Gospel to grow; the desire for comfort, on the contrary, led to sin and thus also to the loss of trust and faith among many.²⁸

Notes

21 ĎURICA, S. M.: Život Konštantína a život Metoda, Panónske legendy. Turany 2013, p. 33

22 ĎURICA, S. M.: Život Konštantína a život Metoda, Panónske legendy, p. 20

23 Ibid., p. 37

24 Ibid., p. 6

25 Ibid., p. 37

26 ŽUPINA, M.: Kresťanská etika a jej miesto v systematickej teológii. Prešov 2003, p. 67

27 KORČÁK, T. – NEÚSTUPNÝ, P.: Romové byli zvyklí jen brát, my je učíme dávat. In: Život Víry. 2011, issue: XII (12), pp. 8–11

28 I personally visited the unnamed preacher in the summer of 2017, and so I knew his situation. I learned the information about the embezzlement of money only much later, when I asked why he was actually no longer in the church. This is not public information, and so it is also difficult to verify.

1.4. The Principles of the Missionary Work of the Holy Apostle Paul and Their Application in the Roma Mission

The Apostle Paul, called the Apostle to the Nations, is one of the greatest missionaries of the Church. He preached the Gospel from Damascus to Spain and gloriously received the gift of martyrdom in Rome in the year 67 after Christ, where three miraculous springs gushed forth at the place of his execution (at the places where Paul's head bounced off the ground). His body lies in the second largest basilica in Rome, beneath the main altar. He is the author of the largest number of pastoral epistles in the Holy Scriptures and an example for all missionaries.

The main driving force of the Apostle Paul's mission was his calling and his love for Christ, who became the centre of his life, as Paul himself testifies: "For to me, to live is Christ."²⁹ The fruit of love for Christ is always love for people, as the Apostle John explains: "If someone says, I love God, and hates his brother, he is a liar; for he who does not love his brother whom he has seen, how can he love God whom he has not seen?"³⁰ The expression of this love is something so self-evident that the judgement after death will take place on the basis of it, as Christ says: "Assuredly, I say to you, inasmuch as you did it to one of the least of these My brethren, you did it to Me."³¹ Paul bore this fruit, and for the salvation and rescue of people he gave everything he had, and in the end his life as well. He also made collections for the poor in Jerusalem, he preached everywhere he went, he prayed and obeyed Christ and the church authorities who sent him out on mission. So as not to be a burden to the faithful, it was no problem for him to renounce meat,³² to work night and day in labour and toil,³³ and to forgive that everyone had abandoned him at his trial.³⁴ However, the greatest proof of his love is his sacrifice: he was willing to renounce his own salvation for the sake of the salvation of his own nation, which scourged him, persecuted him and stoned him more than once. In Paul's missionary method we also observe certain principles:

- a) In a given city he preached first to the Jews and to the proselytes who had accepted Judaism, and only afterwards to the Gentiles
- b) He focused on places where other missionaries had not yet been
- c) He was an example to the local believers; he trained them and involved them in the missionary ministry

d) He did not rely on the wisdom of words, but on the power of God – at the same time, however, he removed all obstacles, such as language, behaviour (customs, conduct) and diet, if they hindered the spread of the Gospel

e) Constant pastoral care and teaching of his spiritual children through co-workers, letters and repeated visits

The Dispersion of the Jews throughout the Empire as a Means of Spreading the Gospel

As is well known, since the Babylonian captivity the Jews were scattered throughout the world of that time, much as the Roma are today. By approaching the Jews first, the Apostle Paul was able to address a large group of people directly in one place set aside for that purpose. Almost always some of the Jews were converted and later, after being driven out of the synagogue, they provided Paul with lodging and a base for further teaching. This was necessary and it made a lot of the work easier. The Apostle Paul himself did not build on this; it looks rather like God's providence. Paul preached in the best place according to the current conditions. When there was no synagogue, he preached by a well, where people gathered to draw water, and in that queue they had time to listen to the Gospel. Elsewhere he preached in the square or in the street, and in Athens he preached on the Areopagus. No conditions were an obstacle for Paul to speak about Jesus, even when the local Church had no base or rented room.

Although the Jews were scattered in various places of the empire, thanks to this Paul found his first refuge precisely with believing Jews, often after his first sermons in the synagogues, to which he, as an educated Pharisee, then had easy access. Thanks to this the Church spread quickly throughout the whole empire.

“...he is a chosen vessel of Mine to bear My name before Gentiles, kings, and the children of Israel. For I will show him how many things he must suffer for My name's sake.”

— Acts 9:15–16

The Apostle Paul Went to Those to Whom Others Did Not Go

Paul writes in one of his epistles that he deliberately preaches the Gospel where others have not yet preached it. This was not pride, but sacrifice and a great deal of work. He was the first to be called by Christ to preach among the Gentiles.³⁵ At the same time, thanks to this he avoided quarrels about who belonged to which teacher and who had

founded which church community. This resulted in several scourgings, a stoning, many imprisonments and many other problems as well. Christ prepared him in advance for these extreme living conditions and for the mission, and He also showed him everything he would have to suffer for Him.³⁶ In Slovakia the Roma from the settlements are a community that most churches perceive as a burden, and they respond to their requests for baptism, marriage and burial with a list of obligations rather than with kindness and joy that they can be a good neighbour to someone. Even visits by Jehovah's Witnesses, which are generally condemned by church authorities as visits by heretics, are tolerated and viewed positively if they take place in the settlements. In the village of Klenovec in Central Slovakia, for example, the situation is such that the Orthodox mission among Roman Catholic Roma in the Lutheran village of Klenovec is welcomed by the Lutherans as well as by the Roman Catholics and the Baptists. All the churches appreciate this mission, because they perceive a great spiritual and also social need. So the settlements are usually open to mission, and no quarrels over believers arise between the individual churches.

Personal Example and Involvement in the Mission

Words are powerful, but one's own example is more powerful. That is why Paul, in cities where there was a problem with laziness and empty philosophizing, preferred to work night and day rather than let himself be supported by the local Church, in order to set a clear example of diligence.³⁷ It did not end with secular work, however. Quite the opposite: Paul taught many and led them to spiritual work and mission as well. He always took one of his co-workers with him on his journeys, and he then sent them with messages to the individual congregations. We know, for example, the evangelists Luke and Mark, the future bishops Timothy and Titus, and many others. From their calling we see how much these journeys helped to build up the next generation of shepherds, who led the Church over a wide territory even before the death of the Apostle Paul. They were not only missionaries; they were also fellow soldiers, fellow prisoners or local people who, when needed, provided space for teaching and lodging for the apostles and their families. They also helped with circulating the epistles, and they helped with prayers, information, clothing and in many other ways.

To the Greeks as a Greek and to the Jews as a Jew

Paul tried to be a Greek to the Greeks and a Jew to the Jews. In this way it was easier for them to accept the Gospel. He was certainly not ashamed of being a Jew – quite the

opposite – but for the sake of the Gospel he set this “pride” aside and adapted to the customs of the local nation. A good example is the occasion when he managed to calm even an enraged crowd of Jews who wanted to kill him. It was enough that he began to speak in Hebrew. I see the same thing in the Roma settlements – when someone speaks in Romani, people listen at once, even when they are agitated, whereas Slovak they take in much more slowly at such moments. In the Apostle Paul this humility also showed itself in matters of food, when we read that rather than scandalize someone by eating meat, he would stop eating meat himself. With his travelling, his frequent stays in prison and his all-day work, this was no small sacrifice. We too can lose a Roma brother by despising his food and his cooking because it is dirty. His heart will harden...

Constant Pastoral Care and Teaching of Spiritual Children through Co-workers, Letters and Repeated Visits

“And I will very gladly spend and be spent for your souls.”³⁸

The Apostle Paul was driven by love, by care for his spiritual children and by concern for their situation. This showed itself in his use of all available means, such as voyages by ship, the post, sending out and training helpers, ordaining bishops, guiding them and repeated visits. When he was free, he preached, went to new places, trained and sent out disciples; when he was in prison, however, he wrote. He rested little; he constantly had his spiritual children in mind and thought about how he could help them to make progress. We know this kind of love from our parents, who often call us even in adulthood to ask how we are doing, visit us when it is possible and often invite us to their home. It is above all children who need this love and care. In the understanding of the Church, these children are the catechumens and new believers. Within the mission, therefore, this care and pastoral work are necessary, so that these believers, shortly after they have sprouted, do not die of drought (from lack of moisture) before they have firmer and more developed roots.

Paul’s strong faith and example are an encouragement for every believer of any nationality. May the Lord send more such missionaries and co-workers.

“Therefore pray the Lord of the harvest to send out labourers into His harvest.”³⁹

Notes

29 Phil 1:21

30 1 John 4:19–20

31 Matt 25:37–40

32 1 Cor 8:13

33 2 Thess 3:8

34 2 Tim 4:16

35 Acts 9:15

36 Acts 9:15

37 2 Cor 12:13 and 2 Thess 3:9

38 2 Cor 12:15

39 Matt 9:38

1.5. The Mission in Klenovec

At present we help as a family. Next to the settlement in Klenovec we have a large family house, and in it a chapel measuring 3x5m. We have converted the kitchen into a games room for all age groups, and outside there is a larger roofed space the size of another room. On the ground floor we also have two toilets, a washing machine and a shower. On the upper floor are the living quarters, where we live as a family of four; I work as a programmer, and we also have rooms available to accommodate guests. The attic is now being converted so that we can accommodate more guests and Roma children when we organize a “sleepover” here.

A hundred metres from our house is a settlement where approximately 180 Roma live. Half of them are children. In the whole village of Klenovec there are about 500 Roma and 2000 “gádže”, although officially there are more than 3000 of us here. We devote ourselves mainly to the very poorest, and we finance the ministry primarily from what we earn, like the Apostle Paul, who together with his co-workers worked night and day,⁴⁰ so that they could proclaim the Gospel in new places as well, would not be a burden to the locals, and would be a good example to lazier believers.

Our mission begins with prayer for all the families from the local settlements. As Christ said, “the true shepherd knows his sheep by name,”⁴¹ which is why I pray for each family from the settlements individually. My wife prays differently, but we pray every day. These prayers began long before the mission. At the beginning I was afraid to go into the settlement, so I only prayed on the hill and looked at the settlement, or I walked through the settlement at night and prayed. The Roma are afraid at night, so they are not out much. I, for my part, was more afraid of the Roma than of the night.

After prayer comes spiritual help, which consists of teaching (on Tuesday and Sunday), visiting the sick, evening prayers and a common divine service (Sunday). We teach above all children and young people, because they are the ones who are most interested in Christ. We do not bypass the parents; rather, we support one another, even though they do not come to our services. There are now 38 Orthodox children and two Orthodox adults in our settlement. Half of them come regularly. After five years of teaching, games and material help, God granted us the grace that the children could approach the holy Mysteries of Repentance, Chrismation and the Eucharist. Since then the mission has experienced growth that is hard to explain, a greater interest in Christ, and we have become one big family. Before, it was mainly about games; now it is

above all about God, and games, teaching and material help are no longer the main reason why most people come to us. The grace of the holy Mysteries was preceded by five years of teaching, conversations, help and example. These years were indispensable and were a kind of substitute for the catechumenate as we know it from the history of the Church. It can certainly be done faster, too. Interestingly, the group of people who came to us from the beginning was replaced by others, so that in practice it was only the second group that became involved in the life of the Church, while the first little group saw life in the Church but remained an observer rather than a participant.

The second pillar is material help for people in need; we try to help the men find work. For the mothers we have more than two tonnes of clothing in the barn, and to hungry families we give out flour and oil so that they can bake bread.⁴² Everything has its rules, so that we do not teach laziness and wastefulness, and because we know everyone from the settlement well, we can approach each person individually according to their problems. Nevertheless, it has almost always paid off for us to be kind and friendly; for when we were strict, people simply shut down. On the contrary, through kindness people who did not work became hard-working fathers and mothers who are closer to the Lord. For the boys we have bricklaying courses, led by our employee Peter Hruška. The boys receive a stipend, with which they buy building materials, tools and shoes. With the building materials they then improve their shacks at home together with their fathers. The girls have a cooking course with my wife once a week. Everything is connected with reading and mathematics.

The Mission in Klenovec in Numbers – February 2022

*“For I was hungry and you gave Me food; I was thirsty and you gave Me drink;
I was a stranger and you took Me in”⁴³*

Ministry to the Roma is dynamic and constantly changing – depending on the month, on the children, and also because the same thing suddenly stops working. Every month is different, and February is when there are the most hungry people. That is why we who serve also spend the most time with Christ in February, as He Himself said: “when you helped the hungry, you helped Me.” We have many activities, but we do not devote that much to them; we try to do good things even if they are not perfect, because “perfect” is the greatest enemy of the good in our local mission. Otherwise nothing

would get done here, and this way we can respond to needs. The table gives exact figures, but one must bear in mind that no two months here have ever been the same.

ACTIVITY	WHEN	ATTENDANCE
Teaching about God	Tuesday, 16:00 –17:00	8 – 20 children, 1 – 2 adults
Prayers and Sunday teaching	Sunday, 8:00 – 9:00 make-up lessons, 9:00 – 10:00 games, 10:00 – 12:00 Prayers, 12:00 – 13:00 teaching for everyone and refreshments	13 – 20 children, 2 – 3 adults
Sunday programme in Mútnik	Sunday, 14:15 – 15:00 games, 15:00 – 15:45 teaching	14 children at games, 7 children and 1 adult at teaching
Games with children in the settlements	As it works out; in summer once a week for 1.5 hrs, and occasionally in the settlement for 30 min.	5 – 20 children
Evening prayers	MON – TUE, THU – SAT 18:00 – 18:45	0 – 5 children
Flour and oil	MON – SUN 7:00 – 8:00	35 adults every week, i.e. 420 kg of flour and 140 litres of oil
Clothing	Suspended in winter, only occasionally and individually	2 – 3 mothers
Work therapy	MON – THU, 9:00 – 17:00	3 adults (primarily for those who are unemployable because of age, mental disability, poor condition and health)
Bricklaying course	MON – THU, 14:00 – 17:00	2 – 3 children every day, but they take turns, so on average 10 children take part each week
Cooking course	Thursday, 14:00 – 17:00	4 children
Lending of games, books, balls		3 times a week someone borrowed something (they must leave their phone with us for that time, otherwise things were not returned to us)
Help with medicines		4 mothers a week (on average) ask for some medicine
Visiting the sick		4 visits in February
Emergency help		4 such situations in February

Orthodoxy Suits the Roma

When a friend who is a Protestant from the Church of the Brethren saw how the Roma children at our place sing prayers, make prostrations, light candles, and kiss the icons and the cross with enthusiasm and open expression of their emotions, he told us with sincere admiration that Orthodoxy suits the Roma incredibly well. Our experience, too, is that although we wean people off superstitions in the settlements, we build on the foundations they have and know – on their love of icons, colours and singing. Unlike the Protestants, we do not run into conflict with their faith; rather, we mend the sails and try to catch the wind.

What the Situation Was Like in Klenovec and the Surrounding Area

Six years ago the fruits of the influence of today's atheistic culture began to be clearly visible in the nearest settlement. Young single mothers of my age appeared in the settlement too, even though until then there had been nothing of the kind. Neighbouring Hnúšť'a is already "further along" in this; it is a larger town, and so they follow the example of television and of the "civilized" gadje from the town. Many of the Roma children I know there are from broken families. One of them already has his third father at home, who has no compassion for him and drinks a lot. Others have several half-siblings, while others never got the chance to be born at all. It also happens that a mother and daughter have children with the same man and raise them together. What effect does this have? The children see no meaning in life, they are not happy, they do badly at school and fall more into drugs and crime. Nowadays the Roma from Hnúšť'a mostly no longer baptize their children.

By the grace of God we have managed to stop "this progress" in our settlement; the next generation of young people is forming stable relationships, accepting children and continuing to baptize them (baptism is a consequence of the fact that they have not rejected faith in God).

I felt like the only tree one could hold on to in the middle of a secularizing flood that destroys the family and morals and calls sexual identity into question. The Roma in Klenovec knew what was right, but they had no one to hold on to. For all the wise of this world go with the times – the media, the teachers, the President, the politicians and friends from university. Public figures, TV presenters and celebrities have broken families, talk about homosexuality as a normal thing, consider masturbation healthy, put their grandparents in care homes and now and then have at least one child with one of the numerous partners they have lived with. And that an ordinary Rom from a

special school would understand this better is very unlikely. These doubts do a lot of damage in upbringing. He then cannot raise his children with certainty about what is right, and the children take on what is easier.

Now Is the Time to Act, and We Can Save Many

“Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit”⁴⁴

The Roma adapt to the religion of the majority. In eastern Slovakia they tend to be Orthodox, while in the neighbouring village, where there is a Roman Catholic church, they are Roman Catholics. Those who stayed in Turkey are now Muslims. From my experience, conversations and visits to various settlements around Slovakia, the present situation looks like this: the missions of the Pentecostals are successful where miracles occur, and the Jehovah’s Witnesses mostly win one family in every third village. The Orthodox, Roman Catholics and Greek Catholics work with their own faithful so that they do not fall prey to present-day secularization and atheism, which is presented at school as the only correct direction, and most television stations and programmes know almost nothing else.

At present there are estimated to be approximately half a million Roma in the territory of Slovakia. Most of them profess Christianity, but they do not go to church. Baptism and a funeral are enough for them. They do, however, have respect for the priest; when he comes to the settlement, you can see it at once. And when a priest visits someone, that person values it, and sometimes it is even enough for him to start going to church afterwards. The doors of the Roma are open to the Church, but gradually, as our culture accepts atheism instead of the Church, the doors are already closing to the Church.

The Roma are mostly generous, and many of them have already saved someone’s life. They do not make money on their children. Rather, they pay for it, but despite all that they accept them with little faith and greater love. They do not worry about money, and money does not matter more to them than a neighbour. They will help a poor person, cook for him and put him up, even if there is no room left except on a chair at the table. They take care of their grandparents and do not send them out of the house when they have become a burden. They have problems such as lying, theft and drunkenness, but not avarice and pride, which is the worst of all sins.

What they lack is a teacher who would explain the faith to them in their own language and would not force his own culture on them. Just as St Nicholas of Japan did not require the Japanese to adopt Russian culture.

Nowadays the Roma are willing to listen about Christ, much like the Slavs when they accepted Christianity and their prince Rastislav asked for a teacher. Slowly, however, the Roma are accepting atheism, which is even further from faith than paganism, and then they come to despise the teachers of the Church as well. The Roma still believe, even if not perfectly; they honour the priest and have reverence before God. But how much longer will it be like this? The “gadje” have rejected God; young people are not to be seen in the Church, because in their wisdom they have spurned God, as the apostle writes: “For since, in the wisdom of God, the world through wisdom did not know God, it pleased God through the foolishness of the message preached to save those who believe.”⁴⁵ Ever since the time of the apostles, mission has been successful mainly among simple people, as St Paul writes further: “For you see your calling, brethren, that not many wise according to the flesh, not many mighty, not many noble, are called. But God has chosen the foolish things of the world to put to shame the wise, and God has chosen the weak things of the world to put to shame the things which are mighty”.

Notes

40 2 Thess 3:8

41 John 10:2–3

42 As in the time of Elijah. We arrived at this gradually; I tried all sorts of things, including on myself, and these are the two cheapest ingredients you can survive on if you are willing at least to bake your own bread. In Brno I used to buy bread rolls and cheese for the homeless, but here by the settlement we could not buy rolls or cheese for so many. Flour and oil are the minimum we give so that no one here ever dies of hunger. We do it like this: they must come before eight in the morning, so that we wean them off laziness (even the manna from heaven could not be gathered after sunrise), and the head of the family (the father) must come. The mothers are willing to do anything, but the problem tends to be the father, who is not willing to work. So sometimes it really is only hunger that makes him. The alternative is pasta, lentils and milk, but we give those rather to hard-working families who are in quarantine, or when the father is ill and cannot work for a longer time. Thank God the Roma help one another a lot, and the worst that has happened was that someone collapsed from hunger and an ambulance had to come. Once a man in the settlement died of cold; I still regret that. Such a foolish thing, which could have been prevented. He had learned to drink alcohol when he was herding sheep. The gadje paid him in alcohol instead of money – and perhaps he would have survived.

43 Matt 25:35

44 Matt 28:19

45 1 Cor 1:11

PRACTICE

2.1. How to Prepare for Mission

When the emperor sent Cyril on mission to the Slavs, Cyril asked for time to pray. He spent this time together with his team in a monastery, in prayer and fasting. Prayer is a necessity before any mission, and fasting is also very useful. It is good to strengthen oneself before going out into the field, to unite with the other believers and above all to draw strength and a blessing from the Lord. We seldom pray for the Roma in the parish, for our unbelieving neighbours, but in my experience this is the first and easiest step towards learning to love them. A priest once said that if you cannot help, then at least pray. Not everyone has the courage to go into a settlement, someone else is not very good at speaking, but everyone can pray. If we take this up as the Church, it will become our mission, and the Roma who come to church later will be welcomed and not condemned. For when someone from the settlement comes to church for the first time, he will smell, he will not be able to last through a longer service, and so he will either disturb others or leave early. And now it is very important whether the faithful will be glad that he too has come to God, or displeased that someone is disturbing them at prayer.

Fear of the Settlement in Klenovec and the First Prayers

I had always been afraid of the Roma; in Brno I had friends who had been attacked or robbed by them. And I did not like them at all; yet I felt sorry for them when I saw them in the settlement, and I knew that they too needed to come to know Christ. If Christ were born in Slovakia in the 21st century, He would be born in a settlement.

But I did not have the courage to go into the settlement, so I began at least to pray for them. I hoped that the Lord would give me the necessary courage. For the first few weeks I mainly prayed for them, sometimes in the meadow above the settlement. Many times I walked through the settlement, but at night, when they were already asleep and no one was outside. They were afraid of the night, and I, for my part, was afraid of them. One day I understood that if I did not begin to love them, I could hardly speak to them about Christ. That same evening I received from the Lord a love for the Roma, and so far nothing has broken it. Not the burgled house, not the broken cross, not the smashed-up clubhouse – only sometimes one has to ask for this love anew.

2.2. How to Take the First Step

Just as Cyril and Methodius did not go empty-handed, so we too, through money – this unrighteous mammon – can make many friends, so that the Lord may receive us into His kingdom.⁴⁶ Cyril and Methodius did not rely on gifts, nor was that their primary concern, but the emperor handed them gifts in order to help them to success in this way too, and to show the Slavs that he respected them and wished them well. The apostles themselves gave much more; their missions often began with miracles and healings. Likewise the prayers of the first Christians were directed to God with the petition that He would work such signs for the sake of the mission: “Stretch out Your hand to heal, and that signs and wonders may be done through the name of Your holy Servant Jesus.”⁴⁷ Many saints gave away their possessions and helped the poor. St Basil the Great built the Basiliad and handed out soup,⁴⁸ and the mother of St Gregory the Theologian was known for her help to the poor.⁴⁹ Missions to the Indians and to indigenous peoples began with gifts, so that the missionaries might gain trust and friendship, and time to learn their language. A material gift is something we understand even without translation and despite all barriers. We too can announce a collection, get involved in projects, or take two plastic bags of children’s clothes and ask in the settlement for a mother whose children are of an age for whom the clothes would be useful. Once we are in the settlement, it is good to ask how they are doing; to ask the men whether there is any work at the moment, and the women how the children are, whether they are healthy and what class they are in. In winter, again, it is good to ask whether they have enough firewood, and the women tend to chat among themselves about what each of them has cooked; from this one can also find out the family’s financial situation (when there is money, there is meat; when there is poverty, there is mostly just soup).

The First Step into the Settlement of Mútník

I got into the settlement of Mútník thanks to a Roma mother of 12 children, whom I was tutoring in mathematics. She told me that she knew even poorer Roma, and I quickly asked her to introduce me to them. When the local Roma women who worked as field social workers found out, one of them, who was responsible for this settlement, joined us. That was very good, because although mother Erika was very willing, she

did not carry much weight in the settlement of Mútnik, whereas the field social worker handled it calmly. She introduced me and created space for me to say something.

Note: Many university students now go to the settlement of Mútnik to do research; it is one of the few settlements without electricity. The students get there through the network of health workers, who are very well coordinated across Slovakia; they are mostly Roma paid by the government to ensure that the Roma are vaccinated. Unlike the field social workers, their results are verifiable, which is why they really do visit the settlements and know the Roma there well.⁵⁰ This is no longer so common among field social workers. The lady who introduced me in the settlement was an exception, but she no longer works at the office. She was truly exceptional in that she knew most of the people from the settlements by name.

The Example of the Heterodox – from a Gift to the Bible

A very successful missionary approach to poor Roma from Bratislava all the way to the Black Sea is “Operation Christmas Child – Operácia vianočné dieťa”. In rich churches in prosperous countries people club together for gifts, Bibles and textbooks. Local churches then distribute these where there is a shortage of them. The condition is to share the Gospel, to prepare a programme and, after handing out the gifts, to invite those present to regular catechesis classes for children, where they learn about Christ. Everything is voluntary, and no one may ever ask for anything in return for a gift (nor require signing up for the course). The gifts are prepared for various age groups and are generous, because they come from countries where there is plenty, and are then distributed in countries where there is need. This cooperation among Christians is very reminiscent of the collections that the Apostle Paul made in the rich (local) churches for the church in Jerusalem, which lived in poverty and want.⁵¹ This project is open to everyone, and one can sign up for it on the website operaciavianocnedieta.sk. Thanks to it we were able to begin catechizing children in one of the settlements, where until then we had gone only to help and to talk.

The Second Step – Regular Visits

Many one-off events take place in the settlements, but few people come regularly. Everything good and of high quality tends to be costly, reflecting the effort that the work required. The Apostle Paul, too, repeatedly visited the individual churches, wrote to them and stayed in contact with them even when he was already working elsewhere. Nowadays the only regular events in the settlements are the visits of the Jehovah’s

Witnesses. These visits are successful; they are not frequent – only once or twice a year they come to talk with people about God.

Note: The experience of the Baptist church in Brno: a lay preacher of this congregation decided to help teach children from a poor Roma community in Brno, which resulted in the creation of a whole new congregation. We know that it was only the third generation they taught that stayed in the church for good.

One-off events help to break the ice, but nothing more can be expected of them. If you then meet the parents or the children in church, at school or in town, you will be closer to one another. We used to go to more distant settlements every winter, and our relationship with them was better afterwards; we sang, talked about God, drank tea, prayed and encouraged them in the faith.

The Roma Have Time and Open Doors

When you knock on the door of the “gadje”, you meet with suspicion and with people who have no time. They quickly find out what you need and go on with the activity you interrupted. The Roma in the settlements are different; it seems to me that it is usual with them that after a little while they offer you coffee and are happy to chat. It is always good to accept the invitation, but not to overdo the visit by mistake. The Roma are very sociable, and so it is hard to tell when your visit is already tiring them or when they need to do something else. They will not tell you, because that would be impolite. If you want to be polite, then it is good to take an interest in their lives – whether they have enough firewood for the winter, how things are with work, with the children, and how the grandparents are. If you are not disgusted by them and you taste what they offer you, it will please them. Mostly they think that the “gadje” find them disgusting and will not even come to see them, let alone drink water or taste food. Here what Christ says is very important: “eat such things as are set before you”.⁵² Later at home you can have some garlic, drink a little alcohol or take chlorella – it helps us in our ministry when we eat somewhere where the hygiene is poorer.

God’s Grace during a Visit

Once I was offered food even by a lady whose house looks literally like a rubbish dump. She collects old rags around the town and has so many of them that she has filled three shacks with them (someone set fire to the previous two, which perhaps also prevented the spread of various crawling insects around the settlement – bedbugs, scabies, cockroaches, fleas). At the time I was with her, she had so many things at

home that she could not get to her bed, and she slept on a 1.2-metre-high heap of clothes next to the bed. She is very fond of cats, which are everywhere, and hiding anything from them in the household is almost impossible. Whatever the conditions in the settlement may be, you would not find anyone there so foolish as to eat anything at her place. Once, on New Year's Eve, when she went missing, a friend and I found her and brought her home from the neighbouring village. Her daughter had been worried about her; she wanted to thank me and offered me food. Since Christ said "eat such things as are set before you," I accepted the invitation with prayer and fear of God. There is no electricity in the house, so I could not really see where they brought the food from, nor what I was eating and drinking – otherwise I probably could not have managed it. I did not understand how, but the food was tasty, and that evening I did not even have diarrhoea, as I used to have before I got used to food from the Roma settlement. Later I found out why – on that very day a lady from the Baptist community had cooked lunch for her to help her family, and I got the leftovers from that portion. Alleluia!

"Tribulation and anguish will come upon every soul of man who does evil – of the Jew first and also of the Greek; but glory, honour and peace to everyone who works what is good – to the Jew first and also to the Greek. For there is no partiality with God."

— Rom 2:9–11

Notes

46 See Luke 16:9

47 Acts 4:30

48 See Basil the Great: Care for the Poor. [franciscanmedia.org](https://www.franciscanmedia.org/minute-meditations/basil-the-great-care-for-the-poor) (online). [accessed 2021-31-12]. Available online: <https://www.franciscanmedia.org/minute-meditations/basil-the-great-care-for-the-poor>

49 See Righteous Nonna, mother of Saint Gregory the Theologian. [oca.org](https://www.oca.org/saints/lives/2019/08/05/102214-righteous-nonna-the-mother-of-st-gregory-the-theologian) (online). [accessed 2019-08-30]. Available online: <https://www.oca.org/saints/lives/2019/08/05/102214-righteous-nonna-the-mother-of-st-gregory-the-theologian>

50 The project is called "Zdravé regióny" (Healthy Regions), and this is their programme 2B; specifically, it is good to contact one of the coordinators of the health-promotion assistants, and he will then put you in touch with the worker in your municipality/locality. The list of coordinators is available at this address: zdraveregiony.eu/zamestnanci-2b/ Nowadays the project has largely shifted its focus to vaccination against the coronavirus and is becoming known above all for this, but it was successfully and well organized long before that and has always been a link between doctors and the Roma from the settlements.

51 1 Cor 16:1–3

52 Luke 10:8

2.3. The Colour of the Roma Settlements: Not All Roma Are Alike

In the settlements there are many different personalities; mostly you will find some moneylender there, who is clever but profits from the misfortune of others. Then sometimes there is also a vajda (headman), who has the final say in the whole settlement. You will find pious people there as well as thieves. Hard workers as well as idlers. And above all, if all is well, you will find many cheerful children there.

Pious Zuzka

In our settlement one of the pious ones is old Zuzka. Once she came to ask whether she might look at our chapel and pray there. I gladly let her in and was pleased at her interest in the chapel that, by the grace of God, we have here. But old Zuzka taught me a great lesson. As soon as she came in, she began to pray and weep, and I stood next to her with our pupil Dominika in awe and humility, because I saw her virtue and, on the other hand, the poverty and superficiality of my own prayers.

Hard-Working Vojto and His Wife Janka

A good example of a hard-working Rom from the settlement is Vojto. He has been working since he was 13. At first he earned all his money for his 11 siblings and his mother, because their father was in prison. When he found a partner, he became independent and began to earn for his new family and his stepdaughter. To his first job he walked 1.5 hours each way to save on the bus fare, and there he earned approximately 10 euros for a whole day of hard work with timber. Later he bought his own chainsaw in order to earn more. That worked, and when he added a car to it and put together his own work crew, he again earned a little more. Now he works in a factory, because more jobs have opened up here for the Roma too, and work with timber is seasonal, so that in winter he (like the other Roma) then lacked money. Alongside his work in the factory he managed to build a house for his brother-in-law, to see to the supply of firewood for his own house, and he also helps his neighbour. His wife also worked in the factory for some time, and they took turns looking after the children and the household. When the other women from the factory came home, they switched on the automatic washing machine. She, however, after carrying in several buckets of water, heated the house, tidied up after the children, heated water for

bathing, cooked dinner and lunch for the next day, and bathed the children. Later she had to carry in water again, start washing semi-automatically in a 30-year-old Romo washing machine, and at the same time keep three children entertained, because her husband is at work while she is at home. On top of that, washing the floor and sweeping are in themselves quite frequent activities in the settlement, because outside there is mud and the children very quickly carry it inside...

Humility and Gratitude for Bare Life

The Roma from Mútník once said, during a research study, that they are grateful for life. By this word we imagine entertainment, friends and trips – each of us whatever he likes. But they mean gratitude for being alive at all, for not being dead, for having been born and being able to exist. I understand it as humility: being grateful for bare life, which truly has a higher value than all the clothes we put on it. I believe this is because they know death and pain. In our settlement someone dies every year (it has 160 inhabitants in all), and everyone there knows each other well. Many Roma weep when at Easter they see on television how Jesus is crucified. I believe this is also because, unlike us, they know what it is like to be injured by a nail. They can better imagine the pain of one nailed to the cross. From their life one can see that at one time there must have been great Christian missions among them, but now it is rather the Jehovah's Witnesses than believers who come to the settlements...

2.4. When Need Is Greatest, God's Help Is Nearest

God works many miracles in the Roma settlements, although it is rather the ridiculous ones that get on television, such as “Jesus on the stovepipe”. Despite all these miracles and God's help, many of the Roma are angry with God, mostly because He allowed the death of their children, or of a little brother or sister.

“..because He has anointed Me to preach the Gospel to the poor; He has sent Me to heal the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovery of sight to the blind, to set at liberty those who are oppressed.”⁵³

One older and respected Rom, Barnabáš, who drove lorries, tells of how God saved him in a car accident that he should not have survived. On the edge of the settlement lives Milan, whose brother was shot dead by a policeman, but he himself miraculously managed to escape. Many years later he was driving drunk and had a very serious crash with his family. Although they were all expected to have permanent consequences, and some only just escaped the gravedigger's spade, in the end no one has any lasting consequences. Except for him – the one who caused the accident. But he too survived the accident, and his wife still speaks of a miracle. Opposite them lives Hana; her mother was supposed to die a few years ago, but God heard Hana and her family, and since then Hana tells of how God saved her mum. Next to Milan lives Jana; she had always been very afraid of the dark, but when she returned to the Church, once when she was outside at night and that great fear seized her again, a supernatural light shone around her. You ask how I know it was supernatural? I know it because from that day on she has no longer been afraid of the dark, which her husband also confirmed to me. One house further on lives Zdena, who does not like priests but will not hear a word against Mary. Once she fled to Mary and prayed fervently in the Church of the Exaltation of the Holy Cross in Hnúšť'a. She then received such a blow from Mary that she fell off the kneeler. But it brought her to such tears and repentance that after these prayers her dying son recovered. A few years later, when she was seriously ill, Mary appeared to her in a dream in a white dress. When she got up in the morning, she found that she was healthy. On the other hand, later, when after all this she behaved disrespectfully towards an image of the Theotokos, it was the worst year of her life. Another of Milan's neighbours had a son who for five years had cried in his sleep every night. This neighbour did not believe in God, but when, after a short prayer, his

son calmed down during his sleep and stopped crying at night altogether, this man put his marriage in order and had his children baptized. These are the first few houses of our settlement, but every family could tell many more stories. God has great compassion for the poor and the suffering, which is why one sees God's grace there much more than among us.

Notes

53 Luke 4:18–19

2.5. Children as the Foundation of the Building

Once a priest who worked with young people was talking with a bishop (vladyka) and wanted to show him how quickly one can gain the trust of young people from the street. He had the carriage stop a short distance from some boys who were playing in the street and spoke to them. The boys ran off, because they were afraid they had done something wrong, but gradually some of them plucked up courage and came closer to the priest. He quickly made friends with them by means of games and funny, instructive stories. Shortly afterwards they parted as very good friends, and the priest got back into the carriage with the bishop.

Father Cristián Popescu, who serves in a church in the Roma quarter of Brno, once firmly calmed down some younger Roma who were behaving inappropriately on the tram. They were very crushed by it, however, so before he got off he gave them little icons, which they were thrilled with.

Our ministry in the Roma settlements, too, rests on work with children; children are willing, curious, unafraid, and often act as our escort in the settlement. My first longer contact with them was football in the settlement; it was enough to bring a ball, and they organized the players themselves. It worked equally well on the Roma housing estate in Hnúšťa – only there you already needed to know someone who would find the players (the children there are not outside as much as in the settlement). Gradually I learned the children's names, began to take them to church after football each time, and then I also got to know their parents when I went to ask them whether the children could go. After the football activities I wanted to deepen the contact and play some more complicated games with them, e.g. a "treasure hunt". There, however, I came up hard against a wall. The games I knew were too complicated; the children could not keep their attention that long in Slovak, nor remember the rules, and so they taught me the games they play. These were hide-and-seek, tag, soldiers, or cat and mouse, which they played at school. And we still play those to this day, alongside the more complicated ones. "Let the little children come to Me, and do not forbid them; for of such is the kingdom of God,"⁵⁴ said Christ, when the disciples considered it more important to attend to everyone else, but not to the children. In Holíč a Pentecostal congregation grew out of teaching children through the programme Operation Christmas Child.⁵⁵ In Brno, on a Roma housing estate, a Salvation Army church came

into being with the motto “take care of the children and in a few years you will see the results”.⁵⁶

The Greek Catholic Roma Mission (hereafter GRM) has a similar story. Today it is successfully active in 20 villages and has already built several centres/churches, even though it started without any resources. In 2021/2022 it is concentrating on building a large centre at Sigord near Prešov. Work with young people through scouting has worked very well for them.⁵⁷ Likewise support for studies (accommodating young people in the parish house so that they could go to secondary school). These young people are now the engine of this mission; they understand its calling and goal and the system of work, and some of them are studying for the priesthood. It is very reminiscent of the working pattern of Don Bosco, who devoted himself to young people from the street and gradually had more and more helpers from within his own ranks rather than from outside. Priests who did not know the organization from the inside lacked the necessary experience of ministry to the young, whereas those who had grown up in it knew the spirit of this ministry and were able to pull together as one. Don Bosco personally led thousands of young people to the priesthood, and they saved abandoned parishes and seminaries and became servants of the young. The second important factor in the success of the GRM was trips and residential stays. During the stays they were able to go more to the heart of the matter with the children, discuss life questions and carry out more comprehensive teaching. In this respect it is very similar to what I know of youth formation among the Protestants. There too, over ten years, it was above all those who had taken part in at least one of the summer or winter stays who joined the youth group, because it was precisely there that relationships were built which are not formed during services or classes.

Notes

⁵⁴ Luke 18:16

⁵⁵ The interdenominational project mentioned above – you can find information about the project at operaciavianocnedieta.sk

⁵⁶ SMÍLEK, P. and family: Já a můj dům budeme sloužit Hospodinu. In: Rozsévač. 2019, vol. LXXXVIII (88), p. 15

⁵⁷ See MEKEL, M., KOLESÁROVÁ, D.: Z osady do kráľovstva. Prešov 2020, p. 38

2.6. Kerygma and the Gospel

Every harvest must be preceded by sowing;⁵⁸ in the practice of the heterodox this is called proclamation or evangelization. It is the proclamation of the foundations of the faith; the emphasis is placed on the resurrection of Jesus Christ, on our redemption and forgiveness, and on the need for repentance and baptism. This is usually combined with personal stories of how God has visibly acted in the lives of those proclaiming, and also with songs about God. It is very similar to the method we know from the Acts of the Apostles, from the Apostle Paul, who when proclaiming the Gospel to judges and rulers often told the story of his own conversion to the Christian faith. Róbert Neupauer also writes about the need for proclamation in Roma communities:

“Specific pastoral attention to the Roma based, for example, only on administering the sacraments is not enough; rather, pastoral activity must begin first with missionary proclamation among them, so that progress may also come about in other areas. The proclaimed Gospel represents a liberating power and helps towards the conversion of heart and mind. And therefore the proclamation of Christ is the first and fundamental factor of development. If someone comes to a Roma settlement where the initial proclamation has not taken place with only a catechetical approach, he will be constantly watering a field in which nothing has been planted. Such pastoral work will be of little effect and frustrating.”⁵⁹

Róbert’s experience from research into Roma communities in the Prešov Region is also confirmed by a community within the Roman Catholic Church called the “Neocatechumenal Way”. It was born among the Roma in a settlement near Madrid, and its first members were thieves and prostitutes. This community spread through proclamation and has more than a million active members. In all the larger cities its members go out into the squares during the feasts of Pascha and proclaim for several weeks. Meanwhile they sing psalms and tell how God has changed their lives. For those interested, a course of teaching is then prepared every week over a period of two months, after which there is a three-day retreat full of teaching, concluded by a call to enter the “catechumenate”. With this the individual becomes a member of the community and, together with this community, passes through stages lasting several years, which teach him the Christian life. The Neocatechumenal Way arose from the

study of Kiko Argüello, who felt a strong need for a catechumenate for himself as a baptized but unbelieving person. Many things in their practice draw on the Church Fathers, the catecheses of Cyril of Jerusalem and our knowledge of the early catechumenate. Their service is a combination of the Liturgy of the Apostle James and the present-day Roman Catholic liturgy. Kiko Argüello is an iconographer and a musician; he was a baptized atheist who won the national art prize in Spain. In his own words, if he had not come to faith, he would certainly have committed suicide. He lived right in the settlement, studied Orthodox theology in a Roman Catholic environment, his icons resemble Orthodox icons, and it is interesting that this work, which in many respects follows on from Byzantine practice, was once again successful among the Spanish Roma, who, as has already been written, spent more than half a millennium in Byzantium.

Notes

58 Mark 4:3

59 MEKEL, M. – KOLEŠÁROVÁ, D.: Z osady do kráľovstva. Prešov 2020, p. 104

2.7. The Roma and Music

The Roma were, are and will be associated with music. Many Roma are excellent musicians all across Europe. For even more Roma it is also their main source of income. It is a sad fact that guitars and songs in the Roma settlements have by now largely been replaced by televisions and loudspeakers. As a result, the Roma musical ear and talent are slowly fading, which the teachers at the special schools also observe. That does not mean, however, that the Roma have stopped loving music – only that they can no longer create it so well.

“Listen! Behold, a sower went out to sow.”

— Mark 4:3

No One Listened to Me, So I Sang to Them

Music is key for us. It was the first form of preaching that was successful over the long term. Over a few months I learned a few chords and rhythms on the guitar from the internet, and already in the first weeks I began to play the first two-chord song in the settlement. I was led to it by the sad fact that when I began to talk to the children about God, they immediately stopped listening to me, and so I made the decision that if they did not want to listen about God, I would sing to them about God. And it really worked; the generation of that time knows many truths from the songs we learned then. Since then Christian songs, alongside Gipsy Čáve and the rapper Rytmus, have been among the most frequently repeated songs in our settlement.

Christian Roma Songs of the Heterodox

The heterodox – whether Pentecostals, Greek Catholics or Salesians – often use songs and music in their spiritual ministry to the Roma ethnic group. Songs are part of every service. Their initial and regular visits to the settlements, too, are mostly filled above all with songs, and then with proclamation or a sermon, or with the life stories of believing Roma. In Slovakia the Pentecostals have completely adopted Roma melodies and rhythm. These are beautiful songs about God, love and repentance, composed by the Roma themselves. The Greek Catholic mission, headed by the priest Martin Mekel, has for its part created many beautiful songs that are a combination of contemporary European and Roma melodies – their best-known band was called F6 and their largest

musical ensemble is called Bararas. For both the Pentecostals and the GRM it is typical that a band is part of every church community, just as in our churches there is always a cantor.

Songs are an excellent path to the hearts of the Roma; the closer a song is to them culturally, the better it tends to be received. This is visible in the success of the Pentecostals' songs. The GRM's songs, which are not purely Roma, are successful among the "gadje" too; many like them as "those Roma Christian songs", but on YouTube only two of their songs, "O Del man dikhel"⁶⁰ and "Zaplav ma láskou"⁶¹, have more than 100 thousand views, and the most is 176 thousand. The Roma, however, number in the millions, and even though the "gadje" do not know their songs, a song by the choir of the Apostolic Church in Sabinov called "Madara tut phrala"⁶², for example, has 362 thousand views on YouTube.⁶³ Altogether they have about 8 songs that have passed 100 thousand views. And that is just one of several Pentecostal churches. The songs of the GRM and of the Roma Pentecostals can be found on YouTube under the names "F6 Chvály", "Umelecké centrum GRM", "ACS Sol", "ACS Sabinov", "chvály Spišská Nová Ves" or "Dévleskere khére".

Spiritual Roma songs are a good tool for proclaiming the Gospel and for teaching. Among instruments they traditionally love the violin, the cimbalom, keyboards and the guitar. In today's shortage of performers, keyboards and guitar are the most practical. The most visible aspect of songs is, admittedly, their popularity, but we must not forget other aspects as well, such as the fruit of a song and its longevity. Cheerful children's songs wear thin for us over time, and later we come to love the serious ones. Present-day popular music mostly does not last long, and every year the repertoire has to be changed. Folk and classical music, on the other hand, have been listened to for centuries, not to mention church music, which has been here even longer.

Notes

⁶⁰ https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gfmTMg0Yu_A

⁶¹ <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LdHvh8-MO40>

⁶² <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Lpk-INaZsao>

⁶³ That is 50% more than the best-known Kofola Christmas advert with the wild boar

2.8. The First Teaching of Children

In marketing and when new businesses open, one can observe a marked first wave of interest, which grows quickly but also declines quickly, and after that everything is much harder...

From the experience of several people, I too observe that the same thing happens when teaching children in the settlement. When someone comes to the settlement for the first or second time, people come running or peer out curiously to see what this person wants here; the children do not disrupt much, they pay attention and almost all of them come. Then slowly the martyrdom phase arrives, in which it is no longer only you who teach the children, but the children also teach you, the teacher, virtues. What does that mean? Mockery from the children, or thefts “as if” just for a laugh. It is testing the boundaries; nobody normally lets them get away with it, but after all you did not come there to fight or to quarrel. It is best to avoid conflict, but sometimes it cannot be done. As long as only the children are annoying you, it is bearable; but when adults too begin to disrupt the programme, it is considerably worse. I always try to endure it somehow, and in the worst case to leave – once I did not go to one settlement for three months and everything changed for the better. Mostly, however, it was enough for one day to pass. We also have rules: after the second violation a disobedient child must go home; after the third, if he will not obey, he cannot come next time, and so on, until we ban him for a whole month. Besides punishments there are also rewards, such as pens and crayons, which they can buy after a while in exchange for points earned through good behaviour. It is much better when there are two of you; then such difficulties mostly do not even arise. One can take a disobedient child home to his parents and the other can continue with the programme. Overall it helps to deal with disobedient children directly with their parents, or to be under the patronage of some Roma family at whose place you teach and who will keep order for you.

“Take heed to yourselves. If your brother sins against you, rebuke him; and if he repents, forgive him. And if he sins against you seven times in a day, and seven times in a day returns to you, saying, I repent, – you shall forgive him!”⁶⁴

Notes

⁶⁴ Luke 17:4–5

2.9. Thefts

Once a spiritual father came with a sincere heart to Slovakia, to a Roma area, asking whether he might serve the Roma from the settlements there. He burned with sincere love and a desire to help them, and he repeated several times how much he loved them. The local parish priest, M. Kuffa, agreed, even though he had a premonition of how it would turn out. When the next day the spiritual father from Poland brought a large group of Roma to the parish house, thrilled with his success, the parish priest warned him that it could not work like this, because then he himself would not be able to serve other people. He told him that he needed to serve the Roma directly in the settlement.

After a few days the spiritual father returned from the settlement devastated; something was obviously wrong... they had stolen his phone... In keeping with Christ's words, this sincere spiritual father set out for the settlement again, "forgave his enemies", and gave up his mobile. In the Gospel it is written that when someone takes our shirt, we should give him our cloak as well. That was the first time; the second time the Roma stole his car. This time he came back to the parish house really angry. Following the wisdom of our mothers, Father Kuffa first gave him something to eat so that his anger would subside, and then sat down opposite him and asked him to tell him again whether he "loved the Roma".

It is easy to love someone when they do nothing to us, as Christ says: "And if you do good to those who do good to you, what credit is that to you? For even sinners do the same. And if you lend to those from whom you hope to receive back, what credit is that to you? For even sinners lend to sinners to receive as much back. But love your enemies, do good, and lend, hoping for nothing in return; and your reward will be great, and you will be sons of the Most High. For He is kind to the unthankful and evil."

Our Experience

If you are going to serve the Roma, be prepared for them to steal from you sometimes. It is good to be careful, but not too careful, otherwise you will do nothing else. For example, St Paisios, when he noticed a thief, left his own hut and left it open so that the thief could take what he needed.⁶⁵ When I lived alone in the settlement, I did as Father Paisios did and always left my shack open; over time many things "disappeared"⁶⁶ from me, but almost always they left me a little so that I could get by. Then I usually

went to a neighbour, or to those who had robbed me, and asked them for help, saying that someone had robbed me... It was no problem at all, and they were glad to help me. My neighbour always tidied up for me, and no one ever took my laptop, my phone or my guitar. Sweets disappear fastest, then sponges, and in general anything you obviously have a lot of and which, in the visitor's opinion, you will not need all that much. The Roma distinguish what they steal. The Roma we know try to steal things that are not expensive, that you will not miss (e.g. they will not steal a keepsake from your parents), or what they need (nails, a screw, spoons, chairs). My phone travels around our settlement from hand to hand, but whenever I have lent it to someone like that, it has come back to me. I can no longer do this with sweets and toys; those would disappear. In their view a Rom should not steal from a Rom, but unfortunately it happens. In the second settlement I could until recently lend out even toys, but now, after four years, they have started to disappear. In two other settlements, on the other hand, pencils and pens get stolen from me incredibly fast. They probably lack them for school, and it is hard for me to check. But I have to be careful that not too many disappear. For when I did not deal with it, it grew to the point that once about 50 crayons and dozens of pens disappeared. That was a problem, because the next time, when I was getting ready to teach on Sunday, I found that I had no pens, and on a Sunday it was a problem to get hold of so many pens around here. So I came and said that all my pens had been stolen somewhere, and because of that we would write with pencils and crayons today. I think they realized that it was a problem for me, and it helped a bit. As a family we no longer keep the house open all the time, and we lock it. In general we keep an eye on the keys, the finances, the room with the toys, and the sweets. The other things we do not keep under control, otherwise we would not manage to serve. When something disappears, we point it out mainly to the culprit and to the parents, and we try to prevent it in future – mostly these are small things like screws, a sweet, a spoon, tape or a teddy bear. The things we have for them disappear faster, because the Roma understand that nobody wants them anyway, so in their arithmetic they are stealing something worthless, which for them means as if they were stealing nothing... It has improved greatly, however, to such an extent that we can invite the children en masse for sleepovers at our house. All the children in the settlement now know that stealing and lying are sins and try not to do them. If we can convict the culprit, he must return the thing or replace it, but that is exceptional – mostly we cannot convict anyone. Once I read in one of the saints the advice not to waste much time searching out evil, and I have followed it ever since. St John

Chrysostom, too, once praised the catechumens because the fruit of the Holy Spirit could already be seen in them, since they stole less.

The worst thing that happened to me, at the time when I was still alone, was that a boy from our settlement stole my keys and half a year later, together with his cousin, burgled my house. There was a trial, and the police returned the stolen things to me. Some of them no longer worked, but I did not ask for compensation. I just had the feeling that if I did not see it through to the end, they would immediately rob someone else. They were children from families where the father was missing or where the mother had the final say, and she decided that they would not be punished. The whole settlement helped me a great deal at that time.

Whenever people say that the Roma steal and that we should therefore not help them, I reply that missionaries were willing to go even to cannibals, and that it would be a shame if we were now afraid to go to thieves. For how else will they mend their ways and hear the message about Christ?

Notes

⁶⁵ See ISAAK, jeromník: *Život starca Paisija svätorského*. Bratislava 2013, p. 159

⁶⁶ The Roma around us use the word “disappeared”; it is a more socially acceptable word, because with it you avoid directly accusing someone of theft. For example, the sentence “my mobile has disappeared, do you know where it is?” sounds better than “didn’t you steal my mobile?”, and the other person can say “here it is” without having to admit the theft directly. Even that takes a great deal of humility.

2.10. Living in the Settlement

Father Marián Kuffa is known for his help to the poor, but few people know that, under the guidance of his spiritual father, he went to groups very distant from the Church, such as prostitutes, pimps and others. Or that he himself once lived in a Roma settlement in order to help the Roma, and if he did not have other tasks, he would still be helping and living there. He once said that the solution to the Roma question would be if a monk lived in every settlement.⁶⁷ Kiko Argüello, the founder of the “Neocatechumenal Way”, which arose in a Roma settlement near Madrid, where he himself lived for a long time, spoke in a very similar way.⁶⁸ We see the same in the history of the Church, when missionaries not only visited but also lived among the people to whom they proclaimed the Gospel. In Spiš a certain priest lived in a settlement, and the success of his pastoral work is shown by the attendance at his own funeral, where approximately 8,000 Roma were present.

Why would anyone want to live in a settlement? For the sake of the Roma, to help them towards salvation, and for the sake of Christ, to be closer to the suffering and needy and thus to Him Himself. The feast of the Nativity of Jesus Christ, for example, speaks of this with exceptional force; it reminds us how Christ came among us dirty people and was born into even greater dirt – among the cattle. Christ’s words, “If anyone serves Me, let him follow Me; and where I am, there My servant will be also,”⁶⁹ leave us in no doubt that this is a recommended path and one full of honour.

In the Roman Catholic Church several nuns⁷⁰ moved into the settlement in Brezno for five years. They did not last longer than that, but to this day, many years after their departure, the fruit of their work is visible among the Roma in Brezno. Such activities are rare, but they do happen and they bear fruit. And so in March 2017 I too moved into the settlement under the supervision of my spiritual father, and I do not regret it to this day; those were then the happiest years of my life. We still draw on these experiences in our ministry to the Roma, though now as a family.

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⁶⁷ I heard this in one of his sermons available on YouTube. It was one of the reasons why I eventually moved right into the settlement. I met Father Kuffa twice, when I brought someone from our streets to him. At that time he told me that if he could, he himself would live in a settlement, and it was also clear that he would have been glad if I had continued living in the settlement, but he explained to me that it is certainly not for a

family. He said that our mission must be a little to the side because of my wife and children, and that what is needed above all is priests, including Orthodox ones.

68 For three years I was a member of the Neocatechumenal Way in Brno, and much of the preaching and teaching was interpreted catechesis and experience coming directly from Kiko Argüello. Most of it, however, is oral tradition, so it is difficult to cite a source. Kiko Argüello writes about his experiences from the settlement in the book *Kerygma. V barakoch s chudobnými*.

69 John 12:26

70 nuns

2.11. The Family in the Roma Mission

On the basis of the experience of Father Marián Kuffa, who has experience with the Roma mission and also lived in a settlement for missionary reasons, we as a family abandoned our plan to live directly in the settlement. His recommendation was to be somewhere to one side and to help directly in the settlement, in the field. He advised us that it should be separated in some way, so that the safety and protection of my wife and children would be ensured. So we tried to hold all our activities directly in the settlement and later to build a church in the settlement as well. So far, however, all plans to build a church in the settlement have come to nothing, and so we have a chapel at our place. For a while we had a note next to the doorbell saying when people could ring, and we asked everyone who came to come back later – at the time we have set aside for it. A spiritual father once said that as long as people ring, it is right, because then they realize that they need a priest; so if they stop, that is bad. If there is a lot of it, one can set aside a specific time for it and direct people to that time, just as offices, companies and other institutions do. The problem is if you do not show up in the settlement; then you lose contact with the community, you do not know about their problems and their life, and that is not good for the mission. The Greek Catholic priest Martin Mekel, who is the director of the GRM and has five children, lived for a long time with his family next to a settlement in a pastoral centre. He advised us to be careful about whom our children make friends with. It is one thing to welcome everyone and to love them, but another thing to form closer friendships, where the parent must be cautious and keep an eye on his children. Otherwise, among their friends there will also be those who may teach them stealing or prostitution, or make them addicted to drugs.

Father Martin Mekel has many times given long-term lodging to various young Roma at his home, and they were members of his household. Many of them are now leaders and an important part of their mission. At our place Roma who had ended up on the street have lived twice; at present the second of them sleeps in the boiler room, which we lock for the night, and the previous one lived in a room, which we also locked for the night. These, however, are exceptions and individuals whom their own families have rejected, but who are willing to give up alcohol and to work. We have a spiritual-and-work programme, and above all one that fills the whole day, because boredom is the first little step towards crime and problems.

The words of St Paisios, in turn, help us to take a better stance on the question of giving away one's own things, and on thefts:

“When someone is a monk, he must apply God’s justice and can allow them to take his kellion⁷¹ and everything else. But when he is the head of a family, I do not insist that he apply this justice of God and that it should become a cause of grief to the other members of the family. He may apply it only when all the members of the family agree. If you are a monk, you can even give away your house and wander alone from place to place in your podryasnik⁷², you can accept and endure suffering and any injustice. But when others also depend on you, it is not right for one to apply God’s justice while the others grumble, suffer and get angry!”

Notes

71 a little house

72 in a cassock

2.12. Roman Catholic or Orthodox

The ecclesial differences between the Roman Catholic and the Orthodox Church are very hard for the Roma around us to grasp. What they see at first glance is a different Liturgy (if they have been to any Liturgy); then they notice the different size of the church building and the fact that the priest has a beard and a family. Then some of them know from television that the Roman Catholics have a pope. That the Orthodox churches are somehow divided and that there are councils is already beyond their perception, because it is neither on television nor in their everyday life.

Within our mission, even after six years, the Roma still do not understand who a bishop or vладыka actually is. Even when we tell them, they forget it, because they have not yet seen the vладыka and do not know him personally; they do not understand why they need him, since after all there is a priest who keeps coming here, who hears confessions, baptizes, gives Communion and serves the Liturgy. The same applies to monasticism, though they have already seen some monks in action films, so there it is a little better. None of this seems to me suitable for discussing the differences. Here in the area the Roma decide the question of faith according to which church refuses to baptize their child, and then at home they sometimes quarrel in jest like a Lutheran and a Catholic.

The situation in Klenovec is roughly this: whoever is interested knows that we are Orthodox. Because we have icons of the Theotokos in the church and resist iconoclasm, in our teaching we have been classed among the Catholics, with the difference that our priests can have families. Many people here consider me a Catholic parish priest, and some probably also a fornicator, because I have a wife and children. I do have room to explain, but few listen, and of those who hear, few trust. To understand our situation it is worth mentioning the case when, after the first Orthodox baptism at our place, rumours began to spread through the settlement that the newly baptized woman would give birth to a demon instead of a baby, and that ours was a faith of demons. The frightened mother came running to us, and for another month she reassured herself with the fact that no demon had been born to us the year before, but the fruit of this lie could be felt even several months later. Many families stopped talking to her at that time. These are things we actively deal with, but so far we only repeat the Creed without much understanding, and we gradually explain the foundations of faith and ethics.

2.13. Chrismation or a Second Baptism

With the arrival of the Roma into the Orthodox Church comes the necessity of resolving their incorporation into the Church. It is a condition for receiving the Mysteries and for progressing in life. I cannot give an answer; I can only tell our experience and our decision. In Klenovec we decided to proceed in such a way that I more often explain the importance of baptism to unbaptized people from the settlement and call on them to put this in order and to have themselves and their children baptized. Thanks to this, two Roma women were baptized at our place, several Roma in the Roman Catholic church in Hnúšťa, and one family of five in the Lutheran church in Klenovec. The second part was allowing those who actively took part in the services and went to confession to approach the holy Mysteries.⁷³ There it was more complicated, because if we had again called them to baptism, it would have set off a great wave of resentment across the settlement. I myself saw how intensely my own parents went through this pain when two of my brothers had themselves baptized a second time in the Baptist church. The baptism that took place at our place in itself caused a great stir and a lot of gossip – not to mention what a possible rebaptism of the children would probably have caused. I myself converted as a Roman Catholic to the Orthodox Church when I was three years old, and at that time the vладыka of Olomouc and Brno decided on the necessity of a second baptism for my parents, but we children were received into the Church at the same time through chrismation. After a conversation with my spiritual father we therefore agreed, by economy (oikonomia), to administer “only” chrismation, on the condition that if anyone wished to be baptized a second time, we would not put any obstacles in his way, but would support him, whatever that might mean in the settlement. There had never been a chrismation here before, so we decided to use the Latin term “confirmation” for the explanation, which the parents know, and it helped us partly to explain this mystery. Along with that I told the parents and the children that they would become Orthodox. The teaching itself was rather an explanation of this mystery and a preparation for receiving it. The children had to bring an application form, which I gave to the parents, in which the Orthodox Church, confirmation and chrismation were again mentioned. It seems to me that in this way it was received positively, and the parents did not prevent their children from progressing towards receiving “confirmation”, which they knew was to come some time after baptism and that this was how it should be, even though it meant that their

children would be in the Orthodox Church. The children were glad and hoped in God's grace.

In the end the chrismation at our place took place in three waves, and at present we have received in this way into the Church 33 young people (aged 7 to 18) and 1 adult mother of some of these children. The grace of God that we see in their lives, and the way they are progressing towards Christ, confirm the validity and efficacy of these holy Mysteries. My wife and I are the godparents of all of them, and that is also why we continue to teach them in the faith and try to be a good example and a help to them.

Beware of the Differences

The Roma community, unlike the white one, has on average more than one child per woman, and this ratio is increasing. Therefore, if the number of Roma baptisms remains the same (unchanged), it is either because they are adapting to our abortion culture, where money matters more than children, or because the number of believers is already declining; otherwise the number of baptisms ought to be increasing.

The Grace of God in Baptism among the Roma

When I came to the Roma settlement, I did not agree with baptizing children in families where I saw neither the fruit of faith nor correct theory. However, I changed my mind after I noticed that baptized children no longer tend to have so many frightening/tearful dreams. This phenomenon is generally known among the Roma in Hnúšť'a and Klenovec, and it was a lesson in humility for me.

Notes

73 Everyone who wants to confess their sins comes to confession as part of personal repentance. Sometimes the serving priest knows who is a member of the Orthodox Church; at other times he asks me or leaves it to the grace of God.

2.14. The Liturgical Language

The liturgical language was a great concern for me in the local Roma Orthodox mission. Here in Klenovec no one knows Church Slavonic or has even heard of it. In the first years I taught the foundations of the faith and the basic prayers, which also exist in Slovak. Gradually, in games and worksheets, we use the Church Slavonic alphabet so that the children get used to it and slowly learn it. But I knew that for the Roma to be able to progress, we would also need the Liturgy and the holy Mysteries. When a person understands nothing, however, the time in church drags. It is very demanding especially for the Roma from the settlement, who are used to active movement outdoors all day long, and then likewise for the priest, whom they disturb in various ways through their lack of concentration. Thank God, in the end, to my surprise, the Liturgy can be served in Slovak in Klenovec, thanks to which the children have learned to understand the Liturgy and also to sing it. This has meant that they are now able to take part even in Church Slavonic Liturgies when we are on a trip to another parish. They are not experts, but they can follow the text in the Great Sbornik and sing the Liturgy together with the others. Texts help us a great deal. If we have texts, then everyone can follow along and they can go much longer without disturbing, because they are involved and are also much more present in spirit.

2.15. Trips

The Roma love trips; many of them have never been further than the district town, and not very often do they get out of the settlement – to a shop or to the town square. This interest is wonderful compared with how much effort it takes to enthruse the “gadje” of the parish to take part in a pilgrimage. With the Roma this is no problem at all. The other side of the coin, however, is that those who have no interest in the spiritual programme will also come, and they will disturb and cause problems. This problem can also occur directly in the parishes, when, for example, you have a class or a feast and want to invite the Roma who are interested. Their friends then often come too out of curiosity, and they then get bored, and from boredom it is only a small step to problems.

For us trips are a motivation and a reward for the children. At the same time they are an opportunity for them to get to know Orthodox spiritual life in other parishes as well, so that they can also get involved as adults if they should move away from our village. They are likewise an opportunity to get used to several priests. It is evident that it is hard to confess to a different priest. At the same time a trip is a very good opportunity when we have time to build better relationships and to have some more demanding teaching, because the participants are more attentive then. We have given up the big bus trips (30–50 people, once every six months) and now have smaller trips, but more often (10–19 people, once a month). This is better, because we could not look after such a large group properly.

2.16. Missionary Activity in Other Settlements

Together with the dear, now departed Father Milan Gerka we began to cooperate on the Roma mission in the settlement in the village of Závadka. He always supported us in our desire to find out how best to work with the Roma community and to apply it in other parishes too. Once a month we came with eight children from Klenovec to Závadka for Vespers, and beforehand we had about an hour of teaching, singing and prayers together with the children from their settlement. The Roma songbooks and worksheets that we use proved very valuable at that time. The local teacher Silvia was surprised that their children were really learning then. My wife and I prepare the worksheets so that they are adapted to different levels of literacy, so that at our place a boy from the 1st class and his brother from the 9th class learn side by side, and opposite them a forty-year-old man with a mild mental disability, who never learned to read well, is writing. Over time we also began to be more active in a third settlement in the vicinity of Klenovec. Many things began to repeat themselves that remind us of our beginnings. In Závadka, after many years of ministry, it is enough to tell the Roma, and thanks to the ministry of the late Father M. Gerka so many of them come that, for lack of teachers, you have to guard the door and let only some in. By the grace of God and with good materials we, as two teachers, managed to teach 30 children like this in peace and quiet. In Varadka one needs to